

communicate using their channel of choice any hour of the day or night.

However, organisations must realise that the role of a contact centre agent will become more challenging with the introduction of AI. Automation remains most effective with interactions that involve simpler tasks and that do not pull in a lot of different pieces. Here, the human touch is not that critical, and AI can provide straightforward information to customers overnight, during holidays and other times when it can be costly to staff a contact centre. This means that agents will receive a larger percentage of calls that are more complicated and challenging.

When customers need information about a specific problem, recovery from a mistake or a more detailed solution that is too complicated for automation, there is a significant need for a human agent. Here, human interaction is necessary to help relieve frustrations and provide correct responses with the appropriate empathy and emotions (which, at times, is more difficult than just navigating a system).

How AI can be used in a contact centre

Use of AI to assist agents: While an agent listens to a customer during a phone call, AI can run in parallel and do some of the heavy lifting of searching a knowledge base for answers while allowing the agent to focus on the customer interaction. Once the information is presented to the agents, they can review the results in real-time, decide what will work best in each situation, and communicate the response to the customer.

AI also works better if information is coming in from the customer via the written word and/or images in the form of an email or chat session. This removes accents, translations, and other questionable input so that automated processes can easily understand the data and then respond to those interactions. In either

case, once AI is providing accurate information in a consistent manner, the technology can interact directly with customers via a bot.

Use of AI to run analytics in the background: First, predictive contact routing analyses key pieces of information such as whether the caller is a high spender, what kind of products they buy, their sales history, projected future behaviour, and other key factors to route calls to the agent who has the best set of skills to successfully work with the customer.

Second, contact centres can use speech analytics technology to analyse recorded calls with customers (post-call analytics). After listening to a call, AI can identify when a voice inflection goes above a specific threshold level, and discover when and why customers get angry and potentially churn.

Speech analytics technology can also be used on a real-time basis to analyse the tone and inflections of a caller to indicate when they appear frustrated, show anger, and need intervention from a higher skilled agent/supervisor. This is a more expensive use of AI in contact centres, but can provide an opportunity to avoid a negative interaction, making customers happier and increasing company loyalty.

There will always be a percentage of calls that will be fully automated using a form of AI. If an automated system works well, customers may even reach out more frequently to get their answers quickly and easily. This will reduce the time spent waiting in a queue, eliminate the time involved for a human response, and drive down overall costs. However, on the flip side, agents will need to be better trained and require higher skills to deal with the more complicated and sensitive calls that can't be handled through automation, which will offset some of the savings.

Businesses with large budgets can test various AI processes to see what works and what doesn't. But smaller contact centres really need to look at

the time and costs involved before implementing any kind of AI system. To take this step, it is important to ensure that effective training and coaching, workforce management, and other technologies are already in place. Customer satisfaction should be a top priority.

A number of AI services for contact centres are available in the market. Let's take a look at some of the best ones.

Amazon Connect

AWS provides Amazon Connect as a fully managed cloud solution for contact centre automation.

Contact center AI is integrated with DialogFlow, which uses natural language processing (NLP) for voice based heuristic search for customer queries. It also helps to do contextual routing to the required support service, based on the query typed by the end user. A dashboard and analytics are on offer for query related metrics on a day-to-day basis based on ticket status like 'active', 'closed', 'waiting', to name a few. It is a hybrid 'build once and deploy anywhere' solution, and can work on smart devices including Alexa and Siri enabled devices.

AWS Connect helps to build a scalable, resilient IVR solution without any worry about infrastructure, deployment models and integration with other services for a public cloud environment. It is an omni-channel cloud contact centre service with unified machine learning (ML) capabilities to manage the customer and contact centre client (agent) experience seamlessly. It makes setting up a contact centre and chatbots very easy. This can be done without much technical experience as Amazon takes care of most of the technical configuration based on your inputs.

If you don't have much experience in contact centre development, you can make use of the Contact Center Intelligence (CCI) support facility in Amazon, which can help in designing a strategy for the centre. You can choose